Sulaiman of Badakhshan had pledged to conquer as a first step towards Samarqand. Shah Abbas was unsuccessful; and the political turmoil in Turan, meanwhile, settled under the rule of Baqi Khan, nephew of its recently deceased Sultan Abdullah. Both Shah Abbas and Baqi Khan were doing what Akbar had asked Salim to do over two years ago. But Salim was very far from reclaiming the city of his ancestors; instead, in 1602, he marched upon Agra, against his own father.

It wasn't a particularly impressive attempted coup. Having travelled from Allahabad to Etawah with, by some accounts, an army of 30,000 men, Salim turned tail at a stern message from Akbar, telling the prince to proceed alone or be prepared for consequences.

The prolonged war of attrition between Akbar and his eldest son might fill a book on its own. Salim was the son Akbar had most keenly desired; every story of the prince's life begins with an account of Akbar's ceaseless prayers for a child and of how Shaikh Salim Chishti promised him three boys.[23] Abul Fazl makes no secret of Akbar's joy at Salim's birth: 'Delight suffused the brain of the age.' Salim was all that Akbar had ever asked of God.

A decade and a half after Salim was born, Father Monserrate described him as the son 'whom [Akbar] loved best of all'[24] – but the years to come would drive wedge after irretrievable wedge between father and son. The most damaging of these would be Akbar's increasing affection – even preference – for Salim's son, Khusro.

Father Xavier of the third Jesuit mission offers a lovely little glimpse of Akbar doting on his grandson. When the mission arrived in 1595, Akbar showed the Fathers some paintings of Jesus and Mary that their predecessor Rudolf had given him. On seeing the paintings, the Fathers fell to their knees, at which seven-year-old Khusro 'also knelt down, and clasped his hands together. This greatly pleased the King, who turned with a smile to his son the Prince, and father of the child, and said, "Look at your son."'[25]

The previous year, in 1594, when Salim was twenty-five, Akbar raised him to the rank of 10,000, with cavalry from Bengal and Lahore, while Khusro 'who though small in years was great in wisdom' – he was all of six – got a mansab of 5000 and Orissa in fief. Khusro's maternal uncle, Man Singh, now amongst the highest-ranking, most powerful men in Akbar's